Seed-Stage Benchmarks

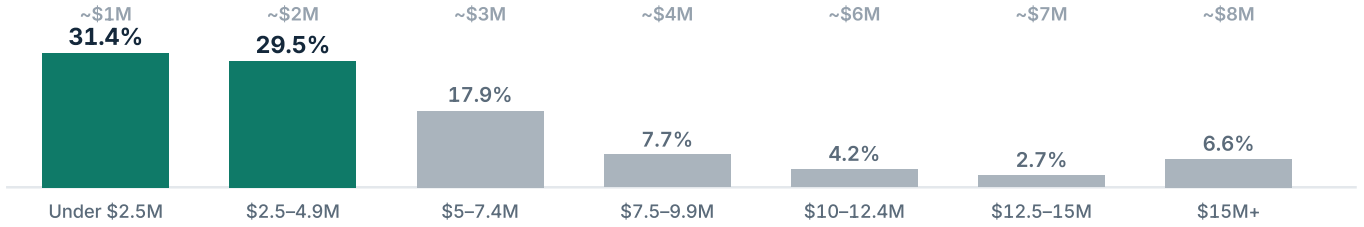
Session 01 · Seed & First Institutional Capital
Data: **Carta** · re-visualized for classroom use

FRONT — RAISING A SEED ROUND & your ownership

TEAL = YOU KEEP · CLAY = YOU GIVE UP

Six in ten seed rounds are under $5M

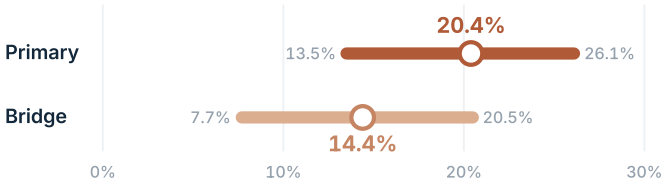
Share of 2025 seed rounds by amount raised — the two **teal** bars are ≈61% of the market. Small figure ≈ the check a lead writes.



CARTA · 1,429 SEED ROUNDS · US · 2025

A priced seed sells about a fifth

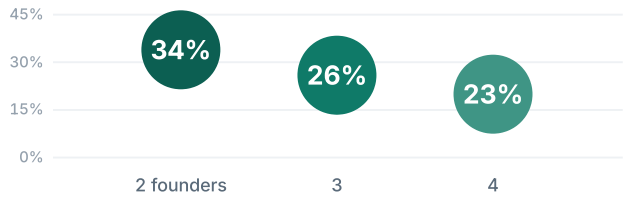
Median % sold to investors — primary vs. bridge. 25th · **median** · 75th.



CARTA · 3,368 PRICED ROUNDS · JAN–SEP 2024

Fewer founders, a bigger slice each

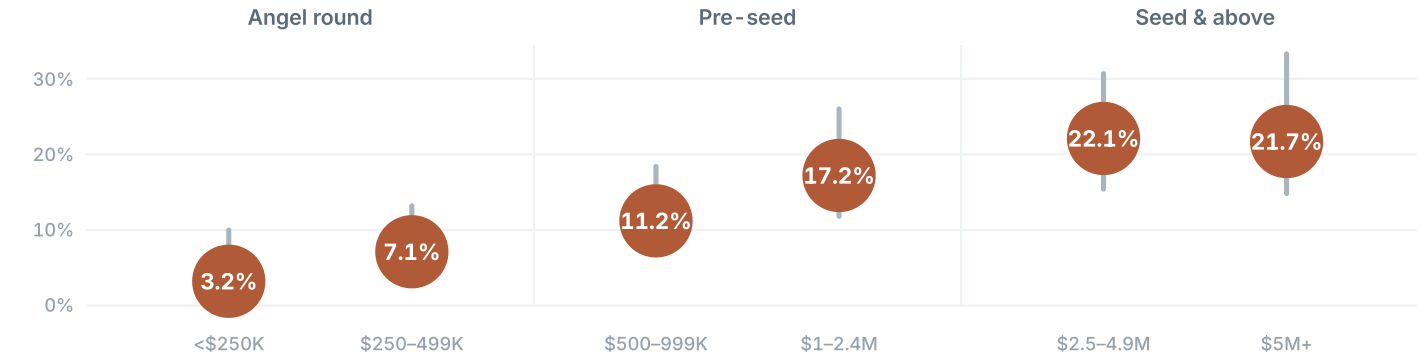
Median equity held per founder at seed, by number of founders.



CARTA · 5,857 STARTUPS · MEDIAN PER FOUNDER

The more you raise on a SAFE, the more you give up

Expected dilution in post-money SAFE rounds — **dot = median**, line = middle-50% range.

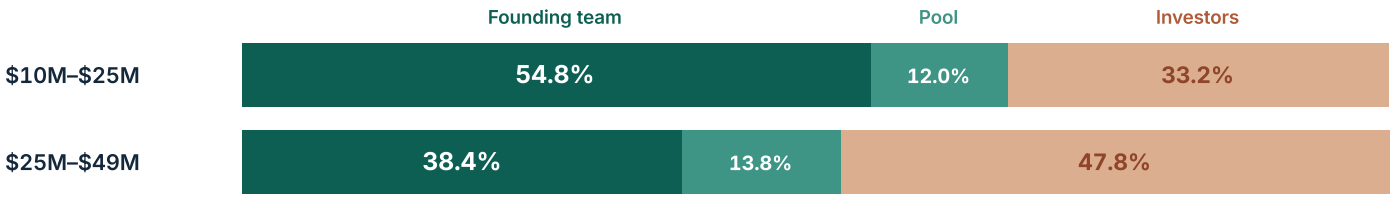


CARTA · 2,414 STARTUPS ON POST-MONEY SAFES · US · 2024

Data © Carta. Used with attribution for classroom instruction.

Founders' majority fades as valuations rise

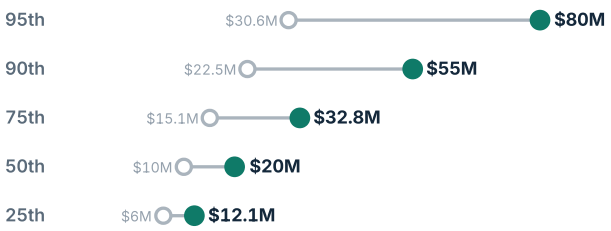
Median ownership split at seed / Series A, by post-money valuation.



CARTA · 10,809 US SOFTWARE STARTUPS · ROUNDS RAISED 2019–2024

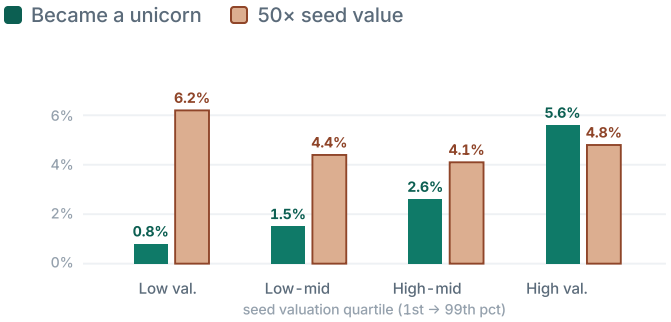
Seed valuations grew fastest at the top

Post-money seed valuation by percentile, 2018 → **2025**. Growth in teal.



CARTA · 12,229 US SEED ROUNDS · Q1 2018–Q3 2025

Pricey seeds make more unicorns — cheap ones 50× more often



CARTA · 5,700 US STARTUPS · SEED 2016–2020 · BY HIGHEST VAL

Each round, most of the field drops out

The class of 2018, stage by stage — share of the original cohort still advancing. Outcomes as of Jan 2025.



By Jan 2025: **62% closed** · **32% still live** · 5.5% M&A · 1.3% unicorn · 0.3% IPO

CARTA · 4,369 COMPANIES INCORPORATED 2018 · STATUS AS OF JAN 1, 2025

How each role vests its equity

Most common vesting terms by role in a U.S. startup — the schedule that turns a grant into ownership you keep.

PERSONA / EQUITY TYPE	VESTS OVER	CLIFF?	FREQUENCY
Founders · Incentive stock options	4 years	1 year (or none)	Monthly
Advisors · Non-qualified stock options	2 years	6 months	Monthly
Independent board · Non-qualified stock options	4 years	1 year	Quarterly
Employees · Incentive stock options or RSUs	4 years	1 year	Monthly

CARTA · MOST COMMON VALUES ACROSS 500,000+ EQUITYHOLDERS AT CARTA COMPANIES

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